

Joy

by Langston Hughes

I went to look for Joy,
Slim, dancing Joy,
Gay, laughing Joy,
Bright-eyed Joy—
And I found her
Driving the butcher's cart
In the arms of the butcher boy!
Such company, such company,
As keeps this young nymph, Joy!

Unearthing Thought

- 1 How do you define joy?
- 2 What is an experience from your own PreK–12 education that brought you joy in learning? What did the teacher do or not do?
- 3 How (often) was joy centered in your teacher preparation, and now in your school or district?
- 4 How are your communities, schools, and classrooms absent of joy?
- 5 How are your communities, schools, and classrooms rich with joy?
- 6 In what ways do you observe joy in your curriculum (instruction and assessment)?
- 7 What do you believe is the purpose of curriculum?

- 8 How do your observations align with your beliefs about the purpose of curriculum?
- 9 What child do you hope your instruction and leadership will cultivate? What are the qualities and characteristics of that child? Will skills-only curriculum and instruction help you nurture that child?
- 10 How do you currently teach and lead for joy?

Strive to Feel Beauty, Wholeness, Wellness, and Happiness

When I was a child, I knew I would become a teacher. The profession was something I chose, but I also feel it chose me. Even when I took other career paths, my journey always wound up back on the teaching path. Teachers were my heroes. While some kids would look up to athletes and entertainers (who were special, too), I looked up to teachers. I wanted to dress

like them, talk like them, and beautifully command presence like them. I watched their teacherly moves and wanted to emulate them. Teachers had power in the world, and I wanted some of that power to change the minds and hearts of others, and my own mind and heart.

So, instead of going home after school and grabbing a microphone to imitate a singer, I grabbed chalk and ink pens to imitate a teacher. I practiced in the mirror, telling children to pay attention to what was on the board, and I would write stories and “lesson plans.” I thought being a teacher could lead to influence. Continuing to teach meant continuing to learn, and put truth into power. Teaching would mark my place in the world and would allow me to give and earn respect. My body and spirit changed when I was playing “school” with my older brother, Abdullah—forcing him to be the one and only student in my makeshift classroom.

That energy continued into adulthood, in various roles and positions I took in the field. I was excited while teaching and learning. I

created curriculum—although I did not call it curriculum then, that is what it was. I noticed how teaching made me feel. I felt whole and motivated. My mind, energy, and spirit were elevated. No matter what I do in my personal or professional life, I always strive to feel beauty, wholeness, wellness, and happiness.

This is joy.

This is why I do my work in the world for educators—I want them, in their work, to have joy.

As *Cultivating Genius* was growing in popularity, the world was responding to racial and other sociopolitical uprisings across the globe. Citizens protested in the streets against anti-Blackness and other forms of hate. The world was also responding to a global pandemic. Teachers and children moved from the classroom to digital platforms—some were prepared, some had to learn and adjust. I was one of those teachers who had to learn and adjust. Some structures in education had to

be paused, such as standardized testing, and some teachers and children felt relief. For some, structures like those are anxiety-producing and don't capture the range of a child's genius.

In those early days of the pandemic, it pained me to lose human contact, but new possibilities opened up, too. Some educators used the freedom to innovate and engage in lessons and units that they may not have tried under traditional pressures, such as the state test. There were educators, too, who addressed the atrocities of the United States, teaching about the lives and deaths of Sister Breonna Taylor and Brother George Floyd. At times, I received emails from teachers telling me they were "in trouble" for teaching lesson plans about Taylor and Floyd, while no leader or parent ever questioned the teaching of other oppressed people, such as Anne Frank. I question the humanity of those who place some injustices front and center, while ignoring others.

With all that was happening in the world, I noticed something: Teachers and children

needed joy more than ever, like the ancestors needed joy when their world was in chaos and turmoil. I knew that joy never comes without justice. Educators began leaving the classroom in droves. In *Cultivating Genius*, I explain how the ancestors embraced joy and beauty in their educational pursuits. Joy and beauty were always their goals, as they cultivated their minds, hearts, and loving practices. While writing the book, I even assumed that educators were naturally embracing joy and beauty, and making them their goals.

But in 2020, I felt we all needed to be (more) intentional about (re)claiming joy, in and outside the classroom. So, I returned to the historical archives of Blackness and searched for joy more deliberately. I found multiple accounts of it, dating from before Africans were stolen from the homelands to after they arrived in United States and had to (re)build their lives.

How the Ancestors Embraced Joy

The ancestors embraced joy in many ways—

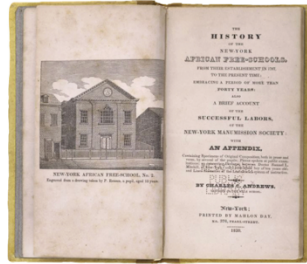
from celebrating life to using their languages and literacies, learning math and science, and creating music and art—before and after striving for freedom (Hannah-Jones, 2021). Joy helped the ancestors to feel whole and, in many ways, provided relief and a purpose for being.

Joy was also solidly connected to their teaching and learning. When I began to read about the centering of joy and justice in historic spaces, such as anti-slavery, benevolent, and literary societies and other collectives, I discovered that many of the ancestors' pursuits carried over to the schools.

The New York African Free School

The pedagogical approaches of the New York African Free School centered joy, as educators sought solutions to society's racism, while centering the truths of students in the elementary and secondary grades. Many members of societies were connected to the New York African Free School, where Black children experienced joy through formal

academics. In 1830, Charles C. Andrews, along with the school's administrators, published a book entitled *The History of the New York African Free Schools*, which outlined the schools' philosophies, schedules, and activities. In daily pursuits there was a blend of social justice and joy. It was written:



Opening pages of *The History of the New York African Free Schools*

It is education—it is the cultivation of the mind and the heart which....leads them [children] to a knowledge of the means, whereby they may insure not only their happiness in the present, but in the world to come (1830, p. 47).

Happiness and joy were important goals of the New York African Free School, yet Andrews and the administrators knew that the way to reach those goals was through abolition, as one educator wrote the same year:

What is the first requisite in paving the way for the total abolition of slavery? We should answer, *education*. What is the second? And third? —our answer will still be as before—education.

The first African Free School was established in 1787 by white “gradual” abolitionists for free Africans, like several historically Black colleges and universities. The African Free School was followed by organized efforts of the Manumission Society in New York City, whose purpose was to help liberate enslaved people. That one school grew to more schools across the city (Foster, 2004).

The established purpose of the New York African Free School was to resist oppression and racism, and move toward liberation, while imparting to children “the benefits of education, as seemed best calculated to fit them for the

enjoyment and right understanding of their future privileges, and relative duties, when they become free men and citizens" (Andrews, 1830, p. 7). Regularly, educators provided notification of student achievement and progress, as well as their promotions in reading, writing, arithmetic, sewing/knitting, elocution, sciences, navigation, astrology, art, and geography. They would have students learn about the state of the world by researching informational texts and writing literary compositions. The publications from which educators designed lessons included:

- *A Father's Legacy to His Children*
- *The Scientific Class Book*
- *Polite Learning*
- *Comstock's and Other Natural History*
- *Scientific Dialogues*
- *Travels at Home*
- *Cook's Travel*

- articles on education, found often in the daily papers



Rosena Disery's poem, "Truth"

The school also lifted and honored children's voices by creating spaces for them to deliver their truths in writing. One common topic for community discussion was called "On Speaking the Truth" (Andrews, 1830). In April 1820, a 15-year-old student, Rosena Disery, wrote and stitched a poem entitled *Truth*, which connects social justice to joy, treasure, and delight.

Children were taught to discuss and write about various topics and issues of the times.

Like Black literary societies, all learning was grounded in literacies and language (including reading, writing, thinking, and speaking/communicating). A seven-year-old at the New York African Free School, during this same time, delivered a speech to practice his elocution. Here is a portion of it:

I am but a little fellow, and know but little. This is my first appearance before you my friends, as a public speaker... I feel a desire to bear my small testimony in favor of the advantages which are derived from a constant attendance at school, and a close application to study while in school, even by the youngest scholar.

The African Free School centered the joy of children by teaching about beauty, aesthetics, and healing, while giving students the space and tools they needed to power their voices. Andrews asked two Black boys to compose poetry on social justice. They wrote:

ON SLAVERY.

Slavery, oh, thou cruel stain,

Thou dost fill my heart with pain:

See my brother, there he stands

Chained by slavery's cruel bands.

Could we not feel a brother's woes,

Relieve the wants he undergoes,

Snatch him from slavery's cruel smart,

And to him freedom's joy impart?

—GEORGE R. ALLEN,
aged 12 years old

ON FREEDOM.

Freedom will break the tyrant's chains,

And shatter all his whole domain;

From slavery she will always free

And all her aim is liberty

—THOMAS S. SIDNEY,
aged 12 years old
(1830, p. 65)

Here, the boys beautifully carried on the tradition of literary Black writers by beginning their titles with the word “On” to emphasize topics that deserved attention and that needed to be captured in time. Their teacher noted that their poems were fully composed and confirmed they were written and signed by the boys (Andrews, 1820). He also noted that young George Allen composed his piece in 30 minutes and Thomas Sidney composed his in one hour. I find both of their writings to be genius and expressions of identity, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy.



The Brownies' Book

The Brownies' Book was a literary magazine developed in 1920 by W. E. B. Du Bois, Augustus Granville Dill, and Jessie Redmon Fauset. It featured stories, plays, letters, poetry, biographies, and other types of texts for children and families (Brooks & McNair, 2008; Harris, 1989). The editors explained in the inaugural issue their purpose:

It aims to be a thing of Joy and Beauty, dealing in Happiness, Laughter and Emulation, and designed especially for Kiddies from Six to Sixteen. It will seek to teach Universal Love and Brotherhood for all little folk—black and brown and yellow and white.

Of course, pictures, stories, letters from little ones, games and oh—everything!

—January 1920

Much like literary societies, *The Brownies' Book* had a wide range of ages of youth who benefited from the text. Like Black newspapers, such as the *Freedom's Journal* of the 19th century, it was developed as a platform to center our stories, as well as our joy. During a time when Black children were excluded, stereotyped, and distorted in children's literature, the developers of *The Brownies' Book* desired just the opposite for them. They established the following goals.

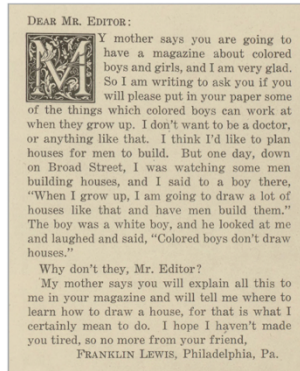
- To make colored children realize that being "colored" is a normal, beautiful thing.
- To make them familiar with the history and achievements of the Negro race.
- To make them aware that other colored children have grown into beautiful, useful and famous persons.
- To teach them a delicate code of honor and action in their relations with white children.

- To turn their little hurts and resentments into emulation, ambition, and love of their homes and companions.
- To point out the best amusements and joys and worthwhile things of life.
- To inspire them to prepare for definite occupations and duties with a broad spirit of sacrifice. (Du Bois, 1919, p. 286)

The editors also centered the voices of young people by encouraging them to write for the magazine. Below is a letter by Franklin Lewis, an aspiring architect from Philadelphia.

The magazine filled gaps in texts that were being offered to all children. The collective writings by children were a manifestation of culturally and historically responsive education, back in the 1800s and early 1900s, with joy as a prominent goal. Again and again, for Black communities, a responsive education was the solution to the turmoil of the world. Black educational history continues to be a guide and blueprint for constructively approaching education today. Learning skills was not enough if it had

no connection to the world and no direction of making it better.



A letter to the editor of *The Brownies' Book* by an ambitious young writer

Black-Centered Schools

Joy continued into the 20th and 21st centuries in communities of color. For example, African- or Black-centered schools carried on the traditions of the New York African Free School. We see this in the history of the Phoenix High School for Colored Youth (1831/1926), Freedom

Schools (1964), Clara Mohammed Schools (1980), and countless other schools PreK–12 that specialized in the teaching and learning of diverse identities, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy. Each school carried on traditions of centering and addressing the urgent needs of people of color, giving children the type of education they deserved. Each one was developed from abolitionist pursuits.

Freedom Schools, for example, were initially created by the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee (SNCC) in 1964, during the notable Freedom Summer in Mississippi. At the time, most African Americans were offered a sharecropper-based education and few opportunities to gain a broader education. Working with the Southern Christian Leadership Conference (SCLC), founders of the Freedom Schools advocated for and promoted the educational needs of Black children (Muhammad & Moodie, 2022). Much like other schools, the purpose of the Freedom Schools was to liberate the hearts and minds of students because of the oppression and

disproportionality in society that they faced. Each day opened with singing and listening to Freedom Songs to energize them and cultivate their joy. Those Freedom Songs were played, too, during the civil rights movement as anthems to the determination of Black people (Hale, 2011). Like members of Black literary societies, Freedom School students met in churches and other educational spaces to read, write, and think together about racism and an anti-racist society (Hale, 2011).



Joy mattered historically, with and without

oppressive conditions. Yet, joy and formal education have never been paired in many spaces. There have been no learning standards for joy, assessments for joy, curricular objectives for joy, teacher evaluations for joy, or a college course on joy in education. Instead, we see remnants of *The New England Primer*, described in [Chapter 1](#). We educators always talk about the importance of joy in teaching and learning, but, still, we rarely see signs of it in our preparation and profession. When teachers and children returned to the classroom as the pandemic numbers declined, they had changed, but curriculum hadn't, for the most part. Many schools simply continued what they were doing before the pandemic. There were few to no classes or college courses on claiming or embracing joy. There were few to no wellness or healing spaces. Too many schools did not offer a robust art program that connected children to the beauty of the earth. That said, when we consider the examples of historical joy I've presented thus far (e.g., New York African Free School, Black Collectives, *The Brownies' Book*,

Freedom Schools), we discover lessons we can learn as we go forward.

10 Lessons of Joy From Historical Examples

1. Joy is defined by one's truths, justice, problem-solving, anti-racism, and anti-oppression.
2. Joy is when we define abolition as education and education as abolition.
3. Joy is liberation and liberty for all.
4. Joy is connected to self-determination and self-empowerment.
5. Joy is when we center love, music, and art.
6. Joy is connected to justice and criticality.
7. Joy is present and experienced when learning is collective and collaborative.
8. Joy is enacted when young people's voices and truths are centered and shared.
9. Joy results from cultivating the mind and heart together.

10. Joy is healing from past and present societal harms.

Now, we must consider how these manifestations of joy show up today and how important they are for teachers and children.

Toward the Pursuit of Joy in Schools Today

In going back to the archives, I added joy as a fifth pursuit to my model of culturally and historically responsive education—the HILL Model—naming all five pursuits because they respond to diverse students' **H**istories, **I**dentities, **L**iteracies, and **L**iberation. In listening to the ancestors (adult and child writers from the 19th century, onward), I found many comprehensive definitions of joy.

Joy is fun and celebratory, yet it is not only about having fun and celebrating in schools

and classrooms (although that is important). It is also the embodiment of, learning of, and practice of love of self and humanity, and care for and help for humanity and the earth. Joy encompasses happiness/smiles, truth, beauty, aesthetics, art, wonder, personal fulfillment, and solutions to the social problems of the world.

Joy is also related to advancing happiness by elevating beauty in humanity, as well as embracing truthful narratives and representations of diverse people of the world (including our students). When students see themselves manifested in our curriculum in diverse and positive ways, we observe their joy. If students only see a single narrative of who they are—wrapped in slavery, for example—what kind of joy would that elicit? The curriculum should be a mirror (where students can see themselves) and a window (where students can see who they can become—including the achievements associated with people like them) (Bishop, 1990). We also observe their joy when we tell them the truth of the world and

give them opportunities to be culturally and historically responsive to those truths.

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Joy can and should be an educational pursuit, where we ask ourselves:

- How does my curriculum and instruction enable, amplify, and spread joy (any type of joy)?
- What types of joy could I bring into the curriculum and instruction?
- How does my curriculum and instruction elevate beauty within humanity?
- How will I write learning objectives that will help my students pursue and embrace joy?

- How will I know if my students are experiencing the learning practices of joy?
- How do I begin with—and convey the joy of—Black people and others who have been historically excluded, marginalized, oppressed, misrepresented, or underserved?
- How do I tell the truth and genius about Black people and others who have been historically excluded, oppressed, misrepresented, or underserved?

Joy of people of color is such an urgent pursuit because of efforts to erase it in schools. One cannot fully experience joy if hurt and harm are being inflicted. For example, when I see sisters such as Breonna Taylor shot and killed at home, what safety, beauty, and joy can I fully experience as a Black woman—thinking that such violence could happen to me—unless I am working against such hurt and harm by using my heart (recognizing and feeling the oppression), mind (thinking deeply about the

problem), tongue (speaking out against it), and pen (writing out against it)?



Again, joy cannot be embraced fully if oppression is present. Furthermore, if I am personally inflicting hurt and harm on myself with negative self-talk, and someone is attempting to cheer me up and help me to see joy while I simply refuse to interrupt my negative self-talk, can joy enter the moment? This is why a balance of criticality and joy is essential. Joy also balances out the teaching of hard truths and histories, such as Indigenous boarding schools, Asian hate, Islamophobia, the Holocaust, and crimes against women and LGBTQ+ people (to name just a few of so many examples). Groups that experienced those truths and histories had joy before injustices

were inflicted upon them. They often used the joy found in painting, music, fashion, and other artistic endeavors to not be overcome with pain. They had happiness, beauty, culture, art, and self-love, even as they were being oppressed. We must begin with their genius, perspectives, and joy, as well as their hard truths and histories.

We should expect joy when we elevate beauty and happiness in the lives of our students when planning and implementing curriculum and instruction. When we center truths about and understandings of the sociopolitical world, students can see themselves fully, and joy can enter their lives.

I consider joy a pursuit—like identity, skills, intellect, and criticality—because it should change and evolve over time, and be student-centered. Unlike “standards,” pursuits move students toward the ultimate goals of self-determination, self-empowerment, and self-liberation, and not just success on a standardized test. Standards are stagnant. They are not created by developers steeped in diverse

cultures. They are not created for individual learners, whereas pursuits come from and are designed for the learner. Joy is what we (re)member from our childhood and our day-to-day lives as adults. My goal is to help you become more intentional in infusing joy into curriculum and instruction.

Educational Pursuits With Joy as the Ultimate Goal

We need stronger curriculum and instruction that capture the histories, experiences, and priorities of people of color. We deserve curriculum and instruction that is invigorating and rigorous to cultivate the intellectual faculties of children. James Banks (1999) identified four major types of curriculum that vary in terms of their quality and effectiveness: contributions, additive, transformation, and social action.

1. **Contributions:** This type of curriculum focuses on surface-level aspects of

culture, such as holidays, traditions, food, and heroes and heroines.

It is, therefore, the least effective and most damaging. Identities within humanity are seen as a token (to be put on or removed from a lesson plan). Those who use this type of curriculum see culture as something that lacks intellectual depth. The only time in the year Black culture may be taught, for example, is through Dr. Martin Luther King Jr., and even when that happens, the fullness of his life, joy, scholarship, and abolition is still not taught.

2. **Additive:** For this type of curriculum, books and other materials are added to an existing curriculum in an attempt to enhance multicultural content, but curriculum is unchanged. It doesn't include perspectives of children of color.

In several audits across the country, I have found Additive curriculum to be the most popular type of curriculum (not written by teachers), even

in cities with rich abolitionist histories, such as New York. Additive curriculum includes (or attempts to include) unit plans that contain some form of multicultural books and ideas, but the objectives, methods, and assessments are not aligned to elements of CRE/CHRE. Merely adding a multicultural book does not equate to CRE/CHRE, nor does it automatically change objectives or assessments. I have seen curricula written only on skills with some suggested and optional multicultural connections. This is especially problematic. Many teachers ask me, *How can I take this curriculum and make it truly culturally responsive?* Before I help, I must first make clear that the content writers never designed the Additive curriculum to be culturally responsive in the first place, and we must ask, *Why have we invested funds, time, and energy in this curriculum? How can we prevent investing funds, time, and energy to a similar curriculum in the future?*

3. **Transformation:** This type of curriculum views issues from multicultural perspectives, and contains more voices. Concepts and objectives include the

voices of those who have been distorted or excluded. Students are encouraged to examine and challenge their own views, values, and beliefs.

This type of curriculum is transformative because it involves collaboration and student voice. Students learn from multiple views, histories, and perspectives that we have historically removed or erased from schooling. They center and explore their own beliefs, as they are encouraged to discern between truth and falsehood.

4. **Social Action:** In this type of curriculum, students engage in authentic problem-solving as they explore ways to effect change (Banks, 1999).

The Social Action curriculum builds upon the Transformation curriculum. Together, they are embedded within Gloria Ladson-Billings's framework of CRE as she conceptualized a CRE curriculum as having:

- academics (students learning content, skills, intellect, strategies)
- cultural competence (students learning about their own cultures and diverse cultures of others)
- sociopolitical consciousness (students learning problem-solving through the lens of equity) (Ladson-Billings, 1994; 2014; 2021)

The Social Action curriculum also connects to the practice of using students' genius, cultures, and gifts to create curriculum and teach them more excellently (Gay, 2010). The need for academics, cultural competence, and sociopolitical consciousness stemmed from the historic limitations, low expectations, and mediocrity of curriculum for children of color in schools. The three components of the Social Action curriculum benefit every child, regardless of background. Yet, due to ignorance and hate, there remains a growing effort to

ban high rigor. There also remains a wide difference between teachers' backgrounds and students', with 80 percent of teachers being white (Schaeffer, 2021), and a large number of "gradual" abolitionists teaching Black and Brown children.

The Next Generation of CRE Curriculum

A fifth type of curriculum, in addition to Banks's four types, would be a blend of Transformation, Social Action, and joy. I argue for five pursuits for every curriculum to advance strategies and methods. This is the next generation of CRE curriculum that every child needs.

Identity is composed of notions of who we are, who others say we are (in both positive and negative ways), and who we desire to be. There is a complex and dynamic dance between the three toward identity development. Identity isn't static; it is moving and changing. And we don't have just one identity, but layers of them.

Identities (cultural and other identities) are constantly being (re)defined and changing. They are fluid, multilayered, and relational, and also shaped by our social and cultural environments, as well as our literacy practices. Our identities encompass many facets, including racial, ethnic, cultural, gender, kinship, academic/intellectual, environmental, personal/individual, sexual, and community.

The focus on identity fosters the learning of individual, family, cultural, and community identities and histories. It also teaches students to know, respect, and value the identities, cultures, and practices of others who may differ from them in any way. Too many schools don't offer students opportunities to learn about the identities of others around the world—others who may be different from them. When teaching children, I avoid saying “different identities” because that language assumes “standard identities.” Instead, I try to say, “different from your own identities.”



Questions to Consider: *How does my curriculum and instruction (including texts, teacher materials, and learning experiences) help students learn, affirm, and/or validate something about their identity(ies) or the identities of someone else? Which (cultural) identities am I teaching now and why? Which identities have I taught throughout the academic year?*

Skills are content-based proficiencies and state standards that empower students to read, write, evaluate, speak, and act confidently, as they seek to imagine and create a more equitable society. Skills are synonymous with competence, ability, and expertise based on what educators deem important to students' learning in ELA and each content area. Skills are what we want students

to be able to “do” across content areas, such as cite textual evidence, solve for x , question the text, make inferences, and draw conclusions. It’s important to remember that state standards are often not rigorous or complete, so they must be adapted and adjusted at times to align with the academic needs of students.

Questions to Consider: *How does my curriculum and instruction (including texts, teacher materials, and learning experiences) help students learn and apply skills independently and meet learning standards for my content area? Which skills and standards am I teaching? Do I need to adapt any state standards to align with students’ needs? Are current state standards building on what students already know? What prerequisite skills are needed for these skills to be learned?*

From W. E. B. Du Bois to Malcolm X to Martin Luther King to Angela Davis, the most influential activists for racial justice have also been intellectuals.

Intellect, or knowledge, is what is learned about various topics, concepts, and paradigms. It is the understanding; exercising and

enhancing mental powers and capacities to better understand, as well as critique the world. Therefore, intellect is connected to action. Intellect is connected to the concepts and themes taught in any unit or lesson plan. Intellect also refers to the new interdisciplinary and cultural knowledge students acquire to become “smarter” about something. From W. E. B. Du Bois to Malcolm X to Martin Luther King to Angela Davis, the most influential activists for racial justice have also been intellectuals. Intellect, therefore, is an essential pursuit of the HILL Model designed to inspire young people to be change agents. Students use intellect to connect and apply skills. Intellect is the pursuit that contextualizes the skill to the world.

Questions to Consider: *How do my curriculum and instruction (including texts, teacher materials, and learning experiences) help students learn (about) new people, places, things, concepts, and ideas? What kinds of new knowledge am I teaching and why? How does that knowledge connect to the world and help students apply skills in the world? What background knowledge*

do students already have? What knowledge do they need before I teach new knowledge?

Criticality asks students to evaluate and dismantle systems of oppression (including, but not limited to, racism, sexism, classism, ageism, xenophobia, ableism, homophobia, and others). Criticality builds social-political consciousness, so students are not passive learners, but rather empathetic, critical thinkers, working to see, name, and root out discrimination and oppression in all forms. Most important, criticality pushes students to ask how they can liberate themselves, their communities, our nation, and our world from discriminatory and oppressive forces. It requires the ability to read, write, think, and speak in ways to understand power and equity in order to understand and promote anti-oppression, as it relates to the content areas. Unlike “critical” with a lowercase “c,” which is just deep, analytical thinking, “Critical” with a capital “C” relates to power, equity, anti-racism, and anti-oppression. As we learn, we must ask, *How am I developing an understanding of power, equity, anti-racism, and anti-*

oppression? The ultimate goal of criticality is to help students become sociopolitically conscious beings, and not passive consumers or producers of information. Criticality helps to cultivate a thinker-student. Rather than passively taking in all information as truthful and just, Critical children question and examine multiple positions and perspectives to develop their voice and truths for the betterment of humanity. There are four major categories of criticality that relate to issues of the hurt, hate, harm, and pain afflicted upon:



1. **The environment.** Topics may include pollution, air quality, land acknowledgment, recycling, unjust/ inequitable thinking and actions

related to taking care of the earth, and other environmental justice topics.

2. **Living organisms.** Topics may include animal abuse, care of plants and other forms of vegetation, and other unjust/ inequitable thinking and actions related to living organisms of the earth.
3. **The self.** Topics may include negative self-talk, self-empowerment, self-reflection of negative/imposed views of beauty and mind, and other unjust/ inequitable thinking and actions related to self.
4. **Other humans.** Topics may include racism, sexism, religious discrimination, homophobia, classism, age discrimination, ableism, xenophobia, and other unjust/ inequitable thinking and actions related to human lives.

A number of criticality topics should be taught throughout the school years, which may depend on student need.

Questions to Consider: *How does my curriculum and instruction (including texts, teacher materials, and learning experiences) help students name, understand, question, and disrupt/interrupt inequities and injustices, such as racism? What Critical topic am I teaching now? Why am I teaching it and why now? What am I disrupting/ interrupting? What do my students already know and understand about this topic? What unlearning do they need?*

Joy is the practice of loving self and humanity; caring for and helping humanity and earth; recognizing truth, beauty, aesthetics, art, and wonder; and working to solve social problems of the world.

Joy is the practice of loving self and humanity; caring for and helping humanity and earth; recognizing truth, beauty, aesthetics, art, and wonder; and working to solve social problems of the world. Joy is also about advancing

happiness by elevating beauty in humanity, as well as truthful narratives and representations of diverse people of the world (including the narratives and representations of our students).

Questions to Consider: *How does the curriculum (including texts, teaching materials, and learning experiences) elevate beauty and joy? How is joy amplified in each of my unit plans? What forms of beauty, truth, justice, happiness, or benefits appear in what I am teaching? What type or form of joy am I teaching and why? Why do students need this type or form of joy? Why now?*

These five pursuits benefit all children, regardless of their background and skill level. The high-performing child in skills benefits as much as the child who struggles to practice skills independently. The HILL model accelerates the learning of all children by placing their skill development in the context of the global world. If they see purpose of their skill learning, students can connect their learning to humanity and higher-level problem-solving.

Why a Model Derived From Black Excellence for All Children?

I'm often asked if the model is only for Black children. To say these five pursuits are only for Black children would be selfish, and Black people have a history of collaboration, not selfishness. Have we asked if other scholars' curriculum and practices are only for white children? When asked why schools should use an educational model for all children derived from Black historical excellence, I focus on these points:

- Historically, Black-centered schools, societies, and other organized spaces were thriving, and have been centers of excellence for learning how to become a stronger and more advanced teacher and leader.
- Black people have brilliantly created, innovated, and found joy amid the harshest oppressions.
- Black diversity and Black history are unique across the world. If we take only

Black history in the U.S., the history of chattel enslavement, and the history of building a country, inventing, creating, and developing models, we will learn so much. We use these innovations every day.

- If you want to transform a system for everyone, start with the group for which we have not gotten it right with the most. According to the U.S. data, we fail Black children the most (National Center for Education Statistics, 2021). If we get it right with them, learning from their histories, we gain the experience to advance the state of education for all.
- Black learning goals, or the five pursuits, are more advanced than what we teach today in schools. The five pursuits are greater than just the one.
- The five pursuits teach the whole child, relating to unique identities, qualities, and needs. What child would not benefit from learning about self and others,

skills, knowledge, and ways to make a better humanity and create joy?

We have to (re)member, Black is diverse. Often, Black people are seen as monolingual African Americans, but there are African roots in many cultures and languages. For those who do not think culturally and historically responsive education is worthwhile, I don't try to sell it to them. In other words, I don't try to sell the need for humanizing practices, nor do I attempt to get "buy-in" on human lives. If those who don't believe in the five pursuits saw all children's lives as they see their children, we would never debate about the five pursuits. Instead, I ask one question: *What kind of child do you want your school and district to cultivate?* In other words, if you could help a child to "become this" or "develop in this way," what would it be? I've been asking this question of teachers, leaders, and parents for a year, and these have been the most common responses:

- Empathic
- Happy and joyful

- Have knowledge about history and current events
- Have positive mental health and social-emotional intelligence
- Inquisitive
- Kind
- Loves self and others
- Problem-solver
- Skillful across disciplines and contents
- Socially just and conscious when it comes to race, culture, gender, class, ability, and other intersectional identities

The next question I ask teachers, leaders, and parents is also simple: *Will a skills-only curriculum get to the kind of child we seek to develop?* The answer is always no. We cannot say we want the “whole child,” but only teach skills, leaving the rest of

what that child needs up to chance or to that future teacher who knows how to move beyond skills. We “trick” others by using words such as “balanced,” “amplify,” and “essentials” to describe curriculum that was not designed to develop the child with these aforementioned qualities.

Students Speak Out

If we listen closely to our students, they will tell us who they are and what they need. We will also find that they deeply desire the five pursuits. As their guest writing educator, I asked middle and high school students from New York City to write two to three sentences explaining who they are, why they write, and the purpose and power of their pens. When they were finished, we put together their statements into a preamble.

Preamble

We, the Youth Authors, are inspirations of beauty. We use our pens to connect our hearts, share our stories

and bring change in the world. Standing here, **we write our hearts out so people can hear the words we might not want to say out loud. Our pens will cross out hate and create spaces for humanity to live in peace—full of intelligence and creativity.** We use our pens to help others be understood. Our pens can connect brains—work as lungs without breath. Our pens can speak, without speaking. Our pens can express what's in our hearts, while mending them at the same time. As future leaders we use **our pens to rewrite a world where we can be one with each other, and harmoniously divine.** It is our joy that fuels it all. **We write to remember ourselves. For we are levitation. We represent the next generation.**

We learn here that diverse young people want: 1) more than just test prep and skills; they desire purpose and connection; 2) learning to reflect their lives, while giving them opportunities to learn about and explore the self; 3) to grow, thrive, and experience beauty and joy in learning; 4) social justice, criticality, and an education that helps to build a better world and humanity for all; and 5) no basic education

or Additive curriculum, for they are “full of intelligence and creativity” and “levitation.” When we compare the children’s words to the type of curriculum they typically receive, we see a large gap. In their writing, I also observe the five pursuits:

1. **Identity** (*We are inspirations of beauty; intelligent, creative future leaders; We write to remember ourselves; We are levitation and represent the next generation.*) When children tell us who they are, we must respond by considering how to teach to all the aspects of their lives.
2. **Skills** (*Our pens can connect brains—work as lungs without breath. Our pens can speak, without speaking. Our pens can express what's in our hearts, while mending them at the same time.*) These young authors can combine sentences, vary sentences, use clear and concise language, and build momentum. And they are clearly skilled at using metaphors.

3. **Intellect** (*Full of intelligence. We use our pens to help others be understood. Our pens can connect brains.*)
4. **Criticality** (*Bring change in the world. Our pens will cross out hate. Our pens will rewrite a world where we can be one with each other*)
5. **Joy** (*We write our hearts. Create spaces for humanity to live in peace. Harmoniously divine. It is our joy that fuels it all.*)

These pursuits connect, work together, and build upon each other. My first hope is that students will see themselves in the text, learning while also having space to learn, and accept who they are and resist who they are not (identity). Next, if children know themselves and feel affirmed and safe, my hope is that they will be more prepared and willing to learn skills. Once they have skills, they can apply them in the world (intellect). Once they develop intellect, students can develop a stance—perspectives on how the topic relates to power, control,

marginalization, injustice, and inequities. Once they've developed a stance, students are ready to develop criticality at an elevated, more advanced level of thought and learning. After students have learned about a Crit topic and thought about how it affects the state of humanity, they are ready for the beauty, aesthetics, healing, solutions, and other joy-related aspects of learning.



Frequently Asked Questions

About the Five Pursuits of the HILL Model

When I visit schools, I am often asked questions about the five pursuits of the HILL Model.

Identity FAQs

1 Am I supposed to teach about all cultures and identities of all my students? Implied within this question may be a desire to avoid teaching (about) any culture or identity to children. Hopefully that is never the case. When I hear this question, I get a sense that the teacher is feeling overwhelmed. To answer it, the teacher must first identify how the model is being used. ([Chapter 5](#) offers examples of uses.) The goal is not to teach all the cultures and identities in the world in one single school year, but to connect every lesson, unit plan, or other learning experience to students' lives in some way. By doing that, every learning experience brings children closer to self or to the lives of other people.

2 What if I don't know (much) about my students' racial, gender, cultural, or other identities? The simplest answer I offer is, Talk to children and, more important, listen to them. It is important to get to know children in authentic, loving, and meaningful ways so that you learn who they are, who they're not, and who they are destined to become on this

earth. If you do not know much about a child's race or other identities, it's important to engage in self-studies and research, honoring who you are as a scholar of the teaching profession. Just as we would not want children to sit in a pool of ignorance, we don't want that for ourselves either. It's important for us to seek knowledge and truths, and read texts (by reliable authors), to understand who our children are.

3 How do I teach identity in watered-down, scripted curriculum? Ideally, your curriculum would be rigorous, multicultural, and excellent. However, if it is watered-down and scripted, start by determining the theme or topic of each lesson or unit plan within it. As long as there is a connection to our world, no matter how small, you can then make connections to the identities of your students. Even in simple decodable books or beginner reading books you'll find a person, place, thing, topic, or concept that appears in the context of the world. Once you have it, you can create learning objectives and

pursuits where students make connections to their lives.

Skills FAQs

1 Skills are hard to teach. How do I teach other pursuits along with that one? Again and again, there is evidence that teaching skills alone is not enough. If the teaching of state standards, proficiencies, and skills is overwhelming, I suggest leaders plan professional learning around content knowledge and methods of teaching. And those leaders may benefit, too, by making it impossible for teachers to fail. Skills may be difficult to teach if they are taught in decontextualized ways and disconnected from students' lives and the world. Are the skills tied only to test prep? In my research, I have found that when skills are taught in concert with other pursuits, such as identity, intellect, criticality, and joy, not only does students' engagement increase, but teachers' professional knowledge and growth do as well. The teaching of other pursuits will never impede the teaching of skills. It will only

enhance the teaching of skills—just as teaching and learning in a second language never inhibits the learning of English. It magnifies it.

2 Who determines which skills “count” or matter in learning? This has been an interesting question for me, as well as for other teachers. To answer it, I question those who write standards (and tests) adopted by their state or school district. I ask their names, about their backgrounds, and if they are leading educators in the field. I want documented examples of how they have taught diverse children successfully. *What is the relationship between standards writers and test writers?* I encourage you to extend state standards, proficiencies, or skills when they are not rigorous enough.

When skills are taught in concert with other pursuits... not only does students' engagement increase, but teachers' professional knowledge and growth do as well.

Typically, committees determine which skills “count” or matter in learning, and as those

committees are developed and organized, we must ask ourselves about the scholarship, theories, models, and frameworks they draw upon to name the skills to be mandated across the content areas to ensure student growth. We must ask whether they go beyond Eurocentric traditions or whether they look wider across communities of color.

3 How do I find time to teach something other than skills? Time is a special and interesting construct. We never get it back once it's gone. Time is typically measured in Eurocentric units, and when people don't fall in line with Eurocentric units, they have come up with new labels to measure it, such as "Black or Brown People's Time," which sometimes denotes being "late" or untimely. When we adhere to Eurocentric measures of time, we begin to care less about humanity and more about so-called measures of other people's time.

When genius is centered, time becomes elusive, and creativity and artistic visions push us to rethink moments and spaces. Time is the one

thing that teachers need more of, and within my PreK–12 organizational plan for the United States, I would not ask teachers to teach for the entire day, but instead give them more time to cultivate and plan out their genius and joy. We are not going to get more time, but we can use our time differently to teach the five pursuits. And if we teach the pursuits in concert with one another, and not in isolation, we will find that we don't need more time; we will use the time we have more wisely to teach all five pursuits. Several of the pursuits, depending on the learning experience, do not require additional time. Some of them can be practiced as homework, while others can be used to introduce a unit plan in the first few minutes. When we think about time, we must recognize that we can use it differently and creatively to tell the rich curricular stories we are teaching our students.

Intellect FAQs

1 What's the difference between knowledge and intellect? How do I teach them in mathematics? Knowledge involves learning new information related to the world. Intellect is knowledge put into action—knowledge that is applied in the world. To connect intellect to mathematics, we must first connect mathematics to the world. One of the purposes of this book is to learn how to become scholars of our content areas or disciplines. Educators must consider issues related to mathematics, including social issues, that can help children learn about new people, places, ideas, and concepts, without sacrificing learning mathematical skills. One helpful approach is to have each mathematics teacher determine one social issue affecting humanity. After determining that issue, ask, *How specifically does math relate to this issue?* From there, create a unit plan about the issue in which students can use math to problem-solve.

2 What if my state standards in science and social studies feel intellectual enough already? Science and social studies

are two PreK–12 content areas with state standards that contain topics that are written as knowledge-based, while English language arts and mathematics use more actionable language in their standards. When that is the case, we can use intellectual pursuits to extend state standards so that as students are learning science and social studies content, they learn it in relationship to the world around them.

3 What's the difference between intellect and skills? We want children to learn skills and actionable proficiencies, and we want them to apply and use those skills independently in the context of the world around them. This is where intellectualism comes in, where children can take skills and apply them to learning new knowledge, across topics relevant to their lives.

4 What should I be reading? I feel like I don't know enough in the world to connect skills to intellect. To cultivate the genius and intellect of our students, we must constantly be cultivating our own genius and

intellect. It is impossible to have knowledge of everything, and that is not the goal. The goal is to be constantly seeking and developing our intellectualism. And as we become smarter about various topics of the world, we will more likely be able to discern which sources of knowledge to bring to students. We then become a community of thinkers and a community of learners.

Criticality FAQs

1 Is criticality only for Black and Brown children? Every time I hear this question, I think, *What if we thought anti-sexist education was only for girls and women?* Of course, the teaching of criticality, of how to make humanity better, is not just for Black and Brown children. One could argue that other populations that have not been oppressed need criticality the most to build knowledge and empathy. Criticality is for all. It elevates the humanity of all.

2 Isn't criticality just critical thinking? As mentioned earlier, criticality is more than just critical thinking. It is critical thinking about power, justice, equity, humanity, problem-solving, empowerment, marginalization, and other types of criticality-related topics. Critical thinking is just deep and analytical thinking that may not necessarily involve racism, sexism, homophobia, classism, ageism, ableism, and other types of oppression.

Where we are today should not be where we are tomorrow, if we know that our children need something greater.

3 What if I am only comfortable teaching certain types of oppression? Part of the journey toward the HILL Model involves unpacking one's own ideologies and self-reflecting. You may have been socialized to feel comfortable teaching some issues of criticality (such as environmental justice) and not others (such as human justice). At times, I work with teachers who feel comfortable teaching about

topics such as “girl power,” but not “Black power,” or they feel comfortable teaching about the beauty and genius of people who are Black, but not people who are LGBTQ+. Where we are today should not be where we are tomorrow, if we know that our children need something greater. So, part of this work requires extending ourselves and stepping into the *uncomfortable spaces of our minds*. To listen, to learn, and to grow, we must not have a scale of oppression and justice, just like we must not have a scale of whose injustices, cultures, and lives deserve our attention in the classroom.

Joy FAQs

1 **Isn't joy mainly for children in preschool and elementary school?** To think that joy is reserved only for young children means that, as adults, you may have never desired, needed, or appreciated a sense of joy in ways that I have (re)defined it in this chapter. We need joy like we need water—like we need air to breathe on this earth. Often, joy is not centered in education as children get older, and we know

there could be a correlation between that fact and lower levels of achievement as children grow older. Joy is for people at any stage of life, including adulthood.

2 **Is joy just having fun and experiencing happiness in the classroom?** As detailed in this chapter, joy is much more than having fun or experiencing happiness in the moment. It is a sustained sense of fulfillment and happiness. When children experience new adversities or hardship, we want them to be able to bounce back and become resilient beings. Teaching them joy helps with sustained happiness, so they don't fall into sadness or self-defeating spaces. Joy is not temporary. It is sustaining a long-lasting form of happiness, self-liberation, and self-beauty of the mind the heart.

3 **How do I teach joy when I also must teach harsh or painful truths of history, such as the Holocaust, enslavement, Indigenous boarding schools, and the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882?** You teach to tell the truth. You never

start Jewish history (or others who have been oppressed) with what oppressors have done to them. You start the teaching with the histories, genius, and joys of the group of people before oppression, enslavement, or colonization. You tell the truth about their beauty. You must also tell the truth about any human who has harmed another.

4 **How do I teach (about) joy if I don't feel joy?** It is difficult to teach about anything when we do not first recognize it, experience it, or enact it. It may not even be possible. If you are not recognizing, experiencing, or enacting joy in your own life, ask yourself, *How can I bring the beauty of the earth to my students in authentic and holistic ways?* This brings me back to my point about the importance of the self-work that's needed to develop our own identities, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy to create joyful pedagogies in the classroom.

Interrupting for Joy

"The paradox of education is precisely this—that as one begins to become conscious one begins to examine the society in which he is being educated."

—JAMES BALDWIN

For humanity to experience joy, we must be conscious of what needs to be interrupted, changed, shifted, and advanced. It is never a question of whether this work is easy or difficult, but instead, Is it possible? And possibility is joy. It is the key to interrupting all that has not served children or educators well. Schools are reflections of society, so as long as there is hurt, pain, and harm in society, we will see them come into our schools, which makes joy even more important. The HILL Model stemmed from research on Black literary societies. *Society* is an interesting word that means "the aggregate of people living together in a more or less ordered community," and we typically think that the wider world, or society, shapes our thinking, language, and actions.

But the ancestors called their abolitionist efforts and organizations "societies," too.

They knew the way to genius, justice, and joy was collectivism and collaboration—and organization. They gave us a model and guide for collective, collaborative joy in education. When there is an erasure or historical exclusion of anyone in society, the HILL Model offers a response to it. This model was birthed out of love, history, justice (consciousness), and joy, and when something is created with those four goals in mind, only success and progress can come from it. Students can only benefit when learning is connected to their worlds, identities, and joys. Their test, college, or career prep will not suffer from the teaching of identity, skills, intellect, criticality, and joy. That teaching will only enhance and elevate their lives. In [Chapter 3](#), I focus on how enhancement and elevation begin with the self.

Chapter 2 Reflection

Select one or more questions to engage in a freewrite.

- What are some reactions and reflections you have about the music, art, and text from [Chapter 2](#)?
- What ideas and passages stand out for you and why?
- What parts do you want to explore further and learn about more?
- What parts of the educational system have helped you grow?
- What parts of the educational system are in need of water?
- What do you plan to do to unearth genius and joy?